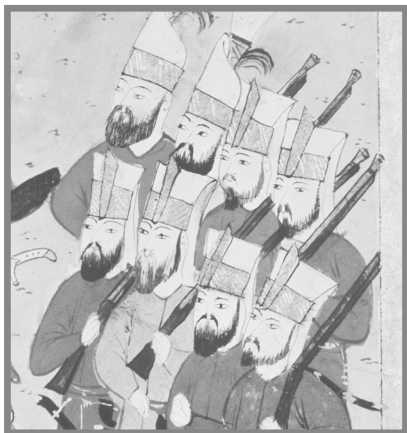




Janissaries wore distinctive uniforms and, unlike other military units, were paid salaries and lived in barracks. They were the first corps to make extensive use of firearms.

local control enabled the Ottomans to hold together a large and diverse empire for much longer than would have been possible with a more wholly centralized system.

The Ottoman army was also crucial to the empire's success. It was technically advanced—employing cannon from the siege of Constantinople onward—and tactically sophisticated. Its high-speed

cavalry units could turn what looked like a retreat into a devastatingly effective flanking attack, surrounding the enemy in a crescent-shaped formation that would take them by surprise.

At the heart of the army were the Janissaries, a unit of infantry that began as the imperial guard and expanded to become the most feared elite force of the period. Initially, the unit was made up of men who, as children, had been abducted from Christian families in the Balkans. Under the *devsirme* system, which was also known as the “blood tax” or “tribute in blood,” boys aged from 8 to 18 were taken by Ottoman military, forcibly converted to Islam, and sent to live with Turkish families, where they learned the Turkish language and customs. They were then given rigorous military training, and any who showed particular talent were selected for specialized roles ranging from archers to engineers.

Janissaries were not permitted to marry until they retired from active duty, but they received special benefits and privileges designed to secure their sole allegiance to the ruler. Although they made up only a small proportion in the Ottoman army, they had a leading role and played a key part in many victories, including those over the Egyptians, Hungarians, and Constantinople.

Mehmed II



Mehmed (1432–1481), the son of the Ottoman emperor Murad II, was born in Edirne, Turkey. As was usual for an heir to the Ottoman throne,

Mehmed had an Islamic education, and at 11 years old was appointed governor of a province, Amasya, to gain experience of leadership. A year later, Murad abdicated in favor of his son, but shortly afterward was called back from his retirement in Anatolia to lend military support. “If you are the Sultan,” Mehmed wrote, “come and lead your armies. If I am the Sultan, I order you to come and lead my armies.”

Mehmed's second, main, rule was from 1451 to 1481. His victory at

Constantinople was followed by a string of further conquests: the Morea (southern Greece), Serbia, the coast of the Black Sea, Wallachia, Bosnia, and part of Crimea. He rebuilt Constantinople as his capital and founded mosques there, while also allowing Christians and Jews to worship freely. Known for his ruthless military leadership, he also welcomed humanists to the capital, encouraged culture, and founded a university.